

## Timeline X

Acer, the world's second largest PC brand launched their latest line of notebooks powered by CULV Core i processors with an 8 hr battery life

## BlackBerry tablet?

BlackBerry is expected to launch a tablet powered by a 1GHz processor by the end of this year

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**H**igh-Definition is a buzzword that should have buzzed by your ears over the past two years with increasing regularity. And for good reason – HD content is here to stay, and for those who haven't gotten their fix yet, it has to be said – you're missing something. HD content is all around and the experience of watching a movie with every detail standing out is an experience. Ask anyone who has seen a Blu-ray version of *Iron Man*. A simple exercise for the non-believer – watch an HD 1080p resolution of the movie and then rent and watch the DVD version. When television service providers jumped on

Airtel and Reliance were clearly not interested in comparison tests for their TV broadcasting services. So this comparison consisted of Dish TV HD and Tata Sky HD – two popular services available all over the country. Earlier, we covered the features on offer by these two service providers, so we won't be covering a lot of features here. We also won't be covering the quality of regular (read non-HD) channels. For making the most out of the HD service, you will require an HD display, preferably one capable of 1080p which is called "full HD". The maximum resolution offered by both Tata and Dish TV is 1080i, 1080p is not possible as it requires significantly more bandwidth. Dish TVs HD service is called "Dish truHD", while Tata Sky calls

# HIGHER DEFINITIONS

After testing various DTH and DVR offerings, we take a closer look at some of the latest HD variants available



to the HD bandwagon we were curious – after all, HD is an oft-abused term. HD also requires a lot of bandwidth, and airing TV channels in HD is no easy task, especially for a bandwidth deprived/restricted (take your pick!) nation as ours. Only a few select channels like National Geographic and Discovery are being aired in high-definition by providers; and we were curious to see how good the services really are. Remember that reception is a subjective thing that differs from region to region, so exceptions cannot be ruled out, but our testing happened in Chembur, Mumbai, out of our new office.

theirs "Tata Sky HD". These are premium services, and you can monitor the charges for Tata Sky HD here: <http://www.tatasky.com/hd/what-will-cost.html> and Dish truHD here: [http://www.dish.tv/in/HD\\_MICRO-SITE/price.html](http://www.dish.tv/in/HD_MICRO-SITE/price.html). Existing customers get a waiver, and at the moment Tata Sky is waiving the installation charges, and offering existing users who upgrade a free subscription to their HD Gold Pack for a year.

Let's take a look at both the options now. The Tata Sky set top box is bigger than the Dish TV one. The remote provided is compact, but it fits the hand nicely. Build quality

is mediocre. Buttons are well laid out and the menu system is pretty intuitive and simple. The Dish TV remote unit is larger, while their set top box is smaller. The remote is much better laid out, with a separate button for games and a good dose of shortcut keys. The main TV menu has a much more intuitive and convenient division of channels. Instead of listing all channels like the Tata Sky interface does, Dish TVs setup divides channels under various headings, like Hindi movies, English movies, kids' entertainment, business news etc. An alphabetic listing is provided, but sadly, this isn't as useful as it sounds. When browsing through channels on the programme guide, the Tata Sky was faster at displaying the schedule of upcoming programmes, whereas on Dish TV, the schedule has a delay of 2-3 seconds. The volume on Dish

to conduct these tests. The display supported multiple HDMI inputs – just what we needed for quickly swapping between both services. We used two HDMI cables to be able to swap between the Tata Sky and Dish TV for testing HD quality. While we could set a channel on Tata Sky and switch to it from Dish TV using the select source on the TV, we couldn't switch back to the Dish TV channel, the Dish TV box requires a restart before it works. This was annoying because every time we had to restart the Dish TV box and re-select the channel. It also spoiled the continuity of viewing that is important to discern finer differences. With the same settings for colour and contrast, the colour on the Dish TV setup seems a little more saturated. There is slightly more noise visible especially in faster moving scenes, and also a little less detail in fast action scenes. Pixellation



TV is slightly louder than the default volume on Tata Sky, and this was noticed mostly with the non-HD channels, although there is a slight difference in the volume of HD content as well.

We used a VU 42-inch LED-backlit, full HD display

on non-HD content seems to be more apparent when compared to Tata Sky, and the noise level with HD content is definitely higher. There also seems to be some minor tearing happening in fast scenes, although this visible with 24p content (movies) and not 30p (television) content.